

The .env File on Clubuntu

The last piece `docker-compose.deploy.yml` needed. Generated and written in one step, entirely on clubuntu — the actual values never passed through this session, this laptop, or git at all.

file: /opt/docker/manpage/.env 2026-08-16

01 Why it was necessary

Every `${VAR}` in `docker-compose.deploy.yml` is a placeholder — Compose fills it in from environment variables, and `.env` in its working directory is where those come from automatically. Without one, every placeholder resolves to an empty string; `postgres` would start with no user, no password, no database name.

WITHOUT `.env`

```
POSTGRES_USER: ${POSTGRES_USER}
resolves to an empty string
postgres fails to initialize correctly
```

WITH `.env` present

```
POSTGRES_USER: codercommands
compose reads .env from its own
working directory automatically
```

Six variables needed it: `POSTGRES_USER`, `POSTGRES_PASSWORD`, `POSTGRES_DB`, `XLSX_HOST_PATH`, `SYNC_POLL_SECONDS`, `GATEWAY_HOST_PORT`.

02 One value needed a real decision: GATEWAY_HOST_PORT

Clubuntu already runs a dozen other projects under `/opt/docker/`, so the dev laptop's default port wasn't safe to assume free. Checked first:

```
$ ssh clubuntu ... "ss -tln"
:5000 in use - the private registry itself, expected
:8100 - not listed, free
```

→ GATEWAY_HOST_PORT=8100, same as dev, confirmed safe rather than assumed

03 The password — generated, never transmitted

Copying `schema.sql` and `coder_commands.xlsx` (doc 6) meant those bytes genuinely traveled over the network, just encrypted. A password is more sensitive still — the safest transfer is the one that never happens. `openssl rand` ran *on clubuntu itself*, inside the same SSH session, so the value was generated, used, and written to disk without ever existing on this laptop or crossing the network as a distinct step.

FILES (doc 6) — generated here, sent there

Dev laptop → (encrypted transit) → clubuntu
bytes genuinely cross the network

PASSWORD — never leaves clubuntu

openssl rand, on clubuntu → .env, on clubuntu
nothing to intercept — it was never sent

the ssh session itself only carried the *script that generates the password*,
never the password value — that only ever existed on clubuntu's own disk

Also never echoed back to this session, this chat, or any log — verification below confirms the file exists and is correctly formed without ever printing its contents.

04 Verified

```
WROTE_ENV_OK
-rw———— 1 katlego katlego 418 Aug 16 12:40
/opt/docker/manpage/.env

--- keys present (values withheld) ---
POSTGRES_USER=
POSTGRES_PASSWORD=
POSTGRES_DB=
XLSX_HOST_PATH=
SYNC_POLL_SECONDS=
GATEWAY_HOST_PORT=
```

Mode `600` — only `katlego` can read this file at all, not even other local accounts on clubuntu. All six expected keys present; values deliberately never printed, including here.

05 **Status of /opt/docker/manpage**

ITEM	STATUS
<code>db/schema.sql</code>	✓ present
<code>coder_commands.xlsx</code>	✓ present
<code>.env</code>	✓ present, mode 600
Directory ownership	✓ katlego:katlego
<code>docker-compose.deploy.yml</code>	not yet — first deploy run copies it in
Self-hosted runner	not yet registered